



Sensory Regulation Guide

Tools and techniques for young people

What is Sensory Regulation?

Sensory regulation is all about how our brains process information from our senses (sight, sound, smell, taste, touch, movement, and body awareness) and how we respond to that information. When our sensory systems are working well, we can manage our environment and our reactions to it. However, for some young people, their sensory systems might be either *over-responsive* (meaning they get easily overwhelmed by sensory input) or *under-responsive* (meaning they might seek out more intense sensory experiences to feel them).

Think of it like a volume knob for your senses. Sometimes it needs to be turned up, and sometimes it needs to be turned down. Sensory regulation is the skill of adjusting that 'volume knob' to help you feel calm, focused, and in control.

Why is it Important?

Good sensory regulation helps you to:

- **Focus and Learn:** When your sensory system isn't constantly buzzing, it's easier to pay attention in class, do homework, or engage in activities.
- **Manage Emotions:** Feeling overwhelmed by sensory input can lead to frustration, anxiety, or meltdowns. Learning to regulate helps you stay calmer and manage big feelings.
- **Socialize:** Being able to participate in social situations without becoming overstimulated or bored makes connecting with others easier.
- **Feel Comfortable:** It helps you feel more comfortable and confident in different environments, whether it's a noisy classroom, a busy playground, or a quiet library.

Sensory Processing Differences

Over-Responsive (Sensory Sensitivity)

This means you might find certain sensory inputs too intense. Things like loud noises, bright lights, strong smells, or certain textures can feel overwhelming.

Common Signs:

- Dislike of loud noises (e.g., vacuum cleaners, alarms)
- Sensitivity to bright lights or fluorescent lights
- Dislike of certain textures in food or clothing
- Easily startled
- Avoids crowds or busy places
- May seem anxious or withdrawn in stimulating environments.

Under-Responsive (Sensory Seeking)

This means you might not notice or respond to sensory input as much, so you might actively seek out more intense sensations.

Common Signs:

- Craves movement (e.g., spinning, jumping, running)
- Enjoys loud noises or strong flavors
- May touch or mouth objects
- Doesn't seem to notice pain or temperature as much
- May appear restless or fidgety
- Can be impulsive.

Sensory Regulation Strategies

The key is to find strategies that work for *you*. What helps one person might not help another. Here are some ideas to try, categorized by the type of sensory input they address:

Auditory (Sound):

- **To Calm:** Listen to quiet music, nature sounds, or white noise. Use noise-canceling headphones or earplugs in loud environments.
- **To Alert:** Listen to upbeat music, sing songs, or tap out rhythms.

Visual (Sight):

- **To Calm:** Dim lights, use a visual timer, look at calming images or nature scenes.
- **To Alert:** Use bright, contrasting colors, look at interesting pictures, or engage in visually stimulating games.

Tactile (Touch):

- **To Calm:** Use weighted blankets or vests, wear soft or seamless clothing, engage in deep pressure activities (like firm hugs), play with playdough or sensory bins.
- **To Alert:** Play with different textures (sand, water, slime), use fidget toys, or try a brisk massage.

Movement/Vestibular (Balance & Motion):

- **To Calm:** Gentle rocking (in a rocking chair or on a swing), slow and controlled movements, yoga poses.
- **To Alert:** Jumping on a trampoline, swinging vigorously, spinning (carefully!), running, or dancing.

Oral (Taste & Smell):

- **To Calm:** Chew on chewy foods (gum, dried fruit), sip on a cool drink, smell calming scents like lavender.
- **To Alert:** Eat crunchy or sour foods, smell strong scents like peppermint or citrus.

Proprioception (Body Awareness/Deep Pressure):

- **To Calm:** Heavy work activities like pushing or pulling objects, carrying heavy items (safely!), rolling up in a blanket, bear hugs.
- **To Alert:** Stretching, pushing against a wall, engaging in rough-and-tumble play (safely!).

Activity: Your Personal Sensory Toolkit

Let's create your own personalized sensory regulation plan! This is a fun way to discover what helps you feel your best.

Instructions:

1. **Get Your Materials:** You'll need a notebook or some paper, pens, markers, and maybe some stickers or drawings.
2. **Think About Your Day:** Imagine a typical day for you. When do you feel most calm? When do you feel most restless, overwhelmed, or sleepy? Mark these times on a timeline or list them.
3. **Identify Your Needs:** For each time of day or situation, think about what sensory input might help you.
 - *Morning:* Do you need to wake up slowly or with energy?
 - *School/Learning:* Do you need help focusing or staying calm?
 - *After School:* Do you need to de-stress or re-energize?
 - *Evening:* How can you wind down for sleep?
4. **Fill Your Toolkit:** In your notebook, create sections for different sensory strategies. You can draw pictures, write words, or even paste in things that represent these strategies.
 - **Calming Corner:** What items or activities help you feel calm? (e.g., a soft blanket, quiet music playlist, coloring pages, a favorite book).
 - **Energizing Zone:** What helps you feel more alert and ready to go? (e.g., a playlist of upbeat songs, space to jump, a crunchy snack).
 - **Focus Boosters:** What can you do for short breaks to help you concentrate?
 - **Sensory Snacks:** List quick sensory inputs you can use anywhere (e.g., a fidget toy, a stress ball, a mint, a few deep breaths).
5. **Test and Tweak:** Try out the strategies you've listed! See what works and what doesn't. It's okay to change your mind and add new things to your toolkit as you learn more about yourself.

Example Page Idea:

My Calming Toolkit:

- *(Drawing of a comfy cushion)* Soft Cushion for Sitting
- *(Picture of headphones)* Quiet Music: "Rainforest Sounds"
- *(Word)* Deep Breaths (Inhale for 4, Hold for 4, Exhale for 6)
- *(Item)* Weighted Lap Pad

Remember:

Sensory regulation is a skill that develops over time. Be patient and kind to yourself as you explore these strategies. If you're struggling, talk to a trusted adult like a parent, teacher, or therapist – they can help you find more personalized support!